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The Lekki Headmaster: Study Guide

Characters, themes, setting and exam practice (UTME Use of English set text)

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Chapter 1: About the Novel and Its Setting

The Lekki Headmaster is a contemporary Nigerian novel by Kabir Alabi Garba. It is divided into twelve chapters and follows the working life and private struggles of a school principal in Lagos. It has been named as a recommended text for the Use of English paper of the UTME, so candidates are expected to know its characters, setting, themes and the way its author tells the story.

This guide is an original study aid written in our own words. It does not reproduce the novel. Read the novel itself first, then use this guide to organise what you have read and to practise for the examination.

Main setting

Most of the action takes place at Stardom Schools in Lekki, Lagos, a private school attended by children of wealthy and influential families. Other settings include Bepo's home and his landlord's house in Ikeja, a passport office in Ibadan, an airport, and the earlier school, Beesway Group of Schools, where Bepo once worked. The United Kingdom, where his family lives, is always present in the background as the place he is expected to move to.

The central story in brief

Mr Adewale Adebepo, known as Bepo, has served for many years as principal of Stardom Schools. His wife, Seri, a nurse, and their daughters, Nike and Kike, live in the United Kingdom, and he is pressed to join them. He loves his work and his country, and he would rather build his nation than help to build another man's. Preparing his travel documents, dealing with agents, and settling his affairs forces him to look back on his career and on what he has meant to his pupils and colleagues. Around this personal struggle the novel shows the daily life of a Lagos school: staff disputes, demanding parents, student rivalries, and the pressure of money and social class.

> **Key point.** The title comes from a nickname. A colleague, the fine arts teacher Mr Audu, calls Bepo "the Lekki Headmaster", comparing him to the headmaster in the well-known television series The Village Headmaster.

Point of view and style

The story is told in a realistic style, with ordinary events, believable dialogue and a mixture of humour and serious moral reflection. The author uses the school as a small model of Nigerian society. When you answer a question on style, mention realism, humour, and the use of a familiar setting to discuss serious issues.

Exercise 1.1

1. Who wrote The Lekki Headmaster?
2. Name the school where most of the story is set.
3. Who gave Bepo his nickname, and what does it refer to?
4. Name two places, apart from Lekki, that appear in the novel.

Answers to Exercise 1.1

1. Kabir Alabi Garba.
2. Stardom Schools, in Lekki, Lagos.
3. Mr Audu; it refers to the headmaster in the television series The Village Headmaster.
4. For example Ibadan (passport office), Ikeja (his landlord's house), the airport, or the United Kingdom.

Chapter summary

- The novel has twelve chapters and is set mainly at Stardom Schools, Lekki, Lagos.
- Its hero, Bepo, is torn between his work and his family abroad.
- The style is realistic, humorous and reflective.

Chapter 2: The Characters

Learn each character by role first, then by what the character shows about the story's themes.

Stardom Schools: management and staff

Character	Role and key facts
Mr Adewale Adebepo (Bepo)	Principal of Stardom Schools; dedicated, patriotic, respected, nicknamed the Lekki Headmaster.
Mrs Ibidun Gloss	Managing Director; inherited the school from her father and tends to put finances and image first.
Chief David Aje	Late founder of Stardom Schools and father of Mrs Gloss; he hired Bepo.
Mrs Grace Apeh	Vice Principal and close colleague who supports Bepo.
Mr Ope Wande	Physics teacher and staff pastor; counsels Bepo.
Mr Audu	Fine arts teacher who coins the nickname.
Mr Fafore	English teacher whose grammar is wrongly criticised by a parent.
Mr Ayesoro	Government teacher moved out of teaching after a parent's complaint.
Mr Oyelana	Christian Religious Knowledge teacher and loyal colleague.
Mr Jeremi Amos	School accountant who later buys Bepo's car.
Mr Ibe	Games master who referees the farewell match.
Nurse Titi	School nurse who helps Bepo when he is distressed.
Jombo	Back-gate security guard.

Family and personal life

Seri is Bepo's wife and a nurse in the United Kingdom; Nike and Kike are their daughters. Mr Ogunwale is Bepo's landlord in Ikeja, and his grandchildren Jide and Kemi attend Bepo's weekend lessons. Sola is a former Stardom teacher now living in the United Kingdom; Bepo once saved her job, and she gives him an honest picture of life abroad. Tai is a passport agent in Ibadan who exploits Bepo's difficulties.

Parents and students

Chief Didi Ogba is a wealthy politician and lawyer, father of the student Tosh. Banky and Tosh are rival SSS 2 students. Mrs Mary Ladele and Mr Guta are parents who make complaints against teachers. Mrs Ignatius is a parent troubled by her marriage; a DNA test needed for visa applications changes her family's life. Ikenna Egbu is a young science student and poet. Mr Egi Meko, director of Beesway Group of Schools, is a corrupt and authoritarian former employer.

> **Exam tip.** Questions often ask who a character is, what job they do, or what they show. Make a short card for each name in the table above.

Exercise 2.1

1. Who is Bepo's wife and where does she live?

2. Which character owns the passport racket in Ibadan?
3. Name the Managing Director of Stardom Schools.
4. Who is the staff pastor?
5. Which two students are rivals?

Answers to Exercise 2.1

1. Seri; she lives in the United Kingdom.
2. Tai.
3. Mrs Ibidun Gloss.
4. Mr Ope Wande.
5. Banky and Tosh.

Chapter summary

- Know each character's role at Stardom Schools, in Bepo's family, and among parents and students.
- Many minor characters illustrate themes such as corruption, class and migration.

Chapter 3: Themes, Lessons and Examination Practice

Major themes

Educational leadership

Bepo leads by example, with discipline, values, humour and a warm relationship with staff and students. The novel suggests that a school is shaped by the character of its leader.

Migration (the "japa" syndrome)

Many Nigerians leave the country in search of better opportunities. Bepo is pulled between his duty to his family abroad and his love for his country and work. Sola and other emigrants show both the benefits and the hardships of life abroad.

Corruption and integrity

The novel shows examination malpractice, bribery and extortion, for example the passport agent who demands money. Bepo is tested again and again and tries to remain honest.

Class and influence

Wealthy and politically connected parents try to influence school fees, discipline and staff decisions. Complaints against Mr Fafore and Mr Ayesoro show how privilege can damage innocent people.

Family, loyalty and sacrifice

Marriage under strain, parents who depend on a teacher for advice, and the sacrifices made for children all appear in the story.

Lessons from the novel

- Honesty and discipline earn lasting respect.
- Leaders should defend innocent staff against unfair complaints.
- Leaving home for a better life has a cost, and the decision should be made with care.
- Money and status should not be allowed to override fairness in education.

Answering exam questions

Answer in complete, clear sentences, name the character and the event, and state the theme that the event supports. Do not retell the whole story; choose the detail that answers the question.

Exercise 3.1

1. State two themes of the novel and give one example of each.
2. What lesson does the treatment of Mr Ayesoro teach?
3. How does the passport agent illustrate corruption?
4. Describe the style of the novel in one sentence.

Answers to Exercise 3.1

1. Migration: Bepo's struggle over joining his family in the UK. Corruption: Tai demanding money for passport work.
2. Powerful parents can harm a teacher unfairly, so leaders must protect fairness.
3. He takes money improperly from someone who needs a passport.
4. It is realistic and reflective, with humour.

Chapter summary

- The main themes are educational leadership, migration, corruption, class and family.
- Link every example to a theme in your answers.